Experts' Alignment on Disinformation in Times of Generative AI

1. Study Overview & Methodology

- **Objective:** To examine whether different expert groups who mitigate disinformation share common views regarding the risks, responsibilities, and self-competence surrounding generative AI.
- **Sample (N = 92):** Consists of European experts sampled from the European Digital Media Observatory (EDMO) network:
  - **Academics** (n = 47)
  - **Fact-checkers** (n = 29)
  - **Journalists** (specialized in disinformation) (n = 16)
- **Statistical Approach:** Due to small and uneven sample sizes, the study utilized a conservative **Welch's ANOVA**with **Games-Howell post-hoc tests**, backed by non-parametric **Kruskal-Wallis tests** for robustness.
- **Definition of Disinformation:** Grounded in intent and potential harm: content that is verifiably false/misleading, intentionally disseminated, serves economic/political objectives, and has the potential to cause societal harm.

2. Core Findings

Dimension A: Self-Perceived Competence

- **Overall Trend:** Disinformation experts generally report high confidence in their ability to detect and handle AI-generated disinformation.
- **Group Divergence: Fact-checkers feel significantly more competent** ($M = 6.05$ on a 7-point scale) than both academics ($M = 5.27$, $p < .001$) and journalists ($M = 5.10$, $p = .034$). This is largely attributed to their hands-on familiarity with detection tools. No statistically significant difference was found between academics and journalists.

Dimension B: Perceived Risks Posed by Generative AI

- **Areas of Strong Alignment:**
  - **90% of experts agree** that AI-generated disinformation will cause confusion about what is real and fake.
  - **69% agree** it will undermine democratic debate by eroding shared truths.
  - Coexisting perspectives: Experts do not view AI as a fundamentally "new" threat versus a "moral panic" as mutually exclusive; they see it simultaneously as a

    - continuation of long-standing tech challenges and a pressing democratic concern.
- **Group Divergence: Journalists are significantly more alarmist** regarding the psychological impact on audiences. They rated the risk that *"people will stop believing in anything they see"* (M = 5.81) significantly higher than academics (M = 4.85) and fact-checkers (M = 4.62).

Dimension C: Attribution of Responsibility (Legal & Policy Focus)

The steepest divides among experts emerged when determining *who* should mitigate AI-driven disinformation:

- **Online Platforms:** There is a strong baseline consensus that social media platforms bear the primary responsibility (62% strongly agreed). However, **fact-checkers hold platforms significantly more accountable** (M = 6.69) than academics do (M = 6.23, p = .026).
- **News Users (The Public): Academics assign significantly more responsibility to news users** (M = 4.74) than fact-checkers do (M = 3.62, p = 0.006). This reflects the academic focus on structural media literacy.
- **Self-Responsibility: Fact-checkers place significantly higher onus on themselves** (M = 6.07) to debunk content compared to how academics view them (M = 5.38, p = .025).

3. Policy & Legal Implications

For a professor focusing on the legal issues of AI, the following takeaways from the paper are highly relevant:

- **Inconsistent Expert Messaging for Policymakers:** While experts agree on risks, they diverge on solutions. Academics favor **consumer-driven interventions** (e.g., media literacy), while fact-checkers favor **technology-driven, structural social interventions** on platforms. Policymakers must recognize these biases when drafting tech regulations to avoid relying on fragmented expert input.
- **Alignment with current EU frameworks:** The expert consensus heavily reinforces the regulatory direction of the **Digital Services Act (DSA)**, which mandates strict systemic risk mitigation and accountability for Very Large Online Platforms (VLOPs).
    - Conversely, the academic emphasis on user responsibility is only indirectly addressed in current EU policies, such as the voluntary commitments to "empower users" via the *Code of Practice on Disinformation*. It also touches on recent shifts in platform governance, such as Meta's exclusive pivot to community notes for moderation as of January 2025.

4. Study Limitations & Future Directions

- **Geographic Scope:** The findings are heavily specific to the EU expert ecosystem and legal frameworks; they may not mirror the regulatory or state-censorship concerns of the Global South or authoritarian regimes.
- **Perception vs. Reality:** The data captures *self-perceived* competence and subjective preferences. Future legal and social research is needed to see if these differing responsibility assignments actually translate into concrete policy outcomes or actual technical competence.